

Pakorras in The Pouring Rain

In a household of twelve, consistency is rare. Of the few things we've managed to familiarize ourselves with, the pouring rain is arguably our favorite. After weeks of sultry August days that darkened our already tan skin and left rosy burns on our cheeks, *Allah* sent a blessing upon us: rain— rain in the form of a storm. As winds that disrupted the daisies' dancing rolled in, and the sky darkened, droplets fell from the sky. In the dim light of our kitchen, my siblings and I basked in one another's warmth to stop ourselves from shivering in fear of the deafening thunder. As the rain continued raging down, creating a tapping sound on our window stills, the cracking of warm oil was heard in return.

“Let me make pakorras,” my grandma excitedly announced, and just like that, the warmth of familiarity ignited inside us.

While my grandma's hands kneaded the batter, her mouth chattered away on the phone to one of her many sisters in Pakistan. Of the many busy minutes of her life, cooking was a time she reduced herself back to eleven in her mother's kitchen. With motherly hands to guide her, she perfected the meals she'd make at twelve for her sisters after their mother's death, at fifteen for her husband after their *nikah*, at seventeen for her firstborn, and at sixty-one for her six grandchildren in a dimly lit kitchen in New York, far from the land she called home. I knew she was thinking about her home when she announced she was making pakorras, about the pattering of rain in the *bazaars*, about the gentle droplets that cascaded down her back in the wheat fields, about the simplicity of it all.

But that was a different world to her now. As she ended her call, she could no longer smell the jasmine vines that kissed the noses of admirers, taste the juice of Pakistani mangoes in

September, or hear the laughter of her sisters that rung throughout their ancestral home. Broken from her thoughts by the light pattering of tiny feet on marble, her youngest grandchild, Sulayman, grasped his little fist around the end of her *kameez*.

“Potato?” The recognition of the snack from a child who couldn’t even remember any of the summers of his life proved its adoration and value in the household. As the once-raw vegetables transformed into crispy treats, the smell of spice-ridden oil wafted throughout the house, luring people of all ages into the kitchen and out of their damp rooms. The fried potatoes were piled on a single paper plate and were coated in various hot spices– black salt, fennel seeds, and *garam masala*– spices from the heart of Pakistan that blended together to set one’s tongue ablaze. Fingers of all sizes grasped at the snack, and even though some might call the *aloos* potatoes and some are forgetting what the orange sun looks like on the horizon of wheat fields, we are all connected through our ancestors, even when far from our land.

Translations – Urdu/Arabic to English:

1. *Allah*- God
2. *Nikah*- Legal Islamic Marriage
3. *Bazaar*- Multiple Small Shops or Street Vendors
4. *Kameez*- A Traditional Pakistani Dress
5. *Garam Masala*: Hot Spice
6. *Aloos*- Potatoes